

LA Clippers Bounceback: What Broke, What Changed, What It Means

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Executive Summary

After the Clippers opened the season 6–21, Ty Lue put it simply: “We just need to go 35–20.”

Since then, Los Angeles has gone 13–3, and the turnaround has come from execution rather than reinvention. The Clippers have cut down on turnovers, gotten to the free-throw line more often, and are finally converting the same shots they were already creating earlier in the season. The structure of the offense has not changed much, James Harden and Kawhi Leonard still drive it, but the effort level and overall sharpness are noticeably higher.

Over the last 16 games, the Clippers own the second-best offense in the league, operating at a level comparable to teams like Boston and a scorching-hot Charlotte group. This is not the result of one hot week. The trends point to steady improvement across December and January, with gains in efficiency, ball security, and scoring output.

Results

What was broken early

Table 1: Core offensive profile.

Window	GP	W	L	PPG	ORtg	eFG	TOV_rate	FT_rate	3PA_share
Start (1–27)	27	6	21	110.9	110.4	54.6%	16.0%	28.4%	42.5%
Since (28+)	16	13	3	114.8	118.6	56.9%	13.6%	32.0%	45.0%

The early-season Clippers were inefficient and careless.

Through the first 27 games, the offense struggled to turn decent looks into points. Shot efficiency sat well below league average, while turnovers wiped out far too many possessions. Despite the poor results, the Clippers’ shot diet was actually fine. They were taking a healthy number of threes and generating pressure in the half court. The problem was execution. Missed shots, rushed decisions, and empty trips piled up quickly, especially late in games.

Rolling trends (How real is it?)

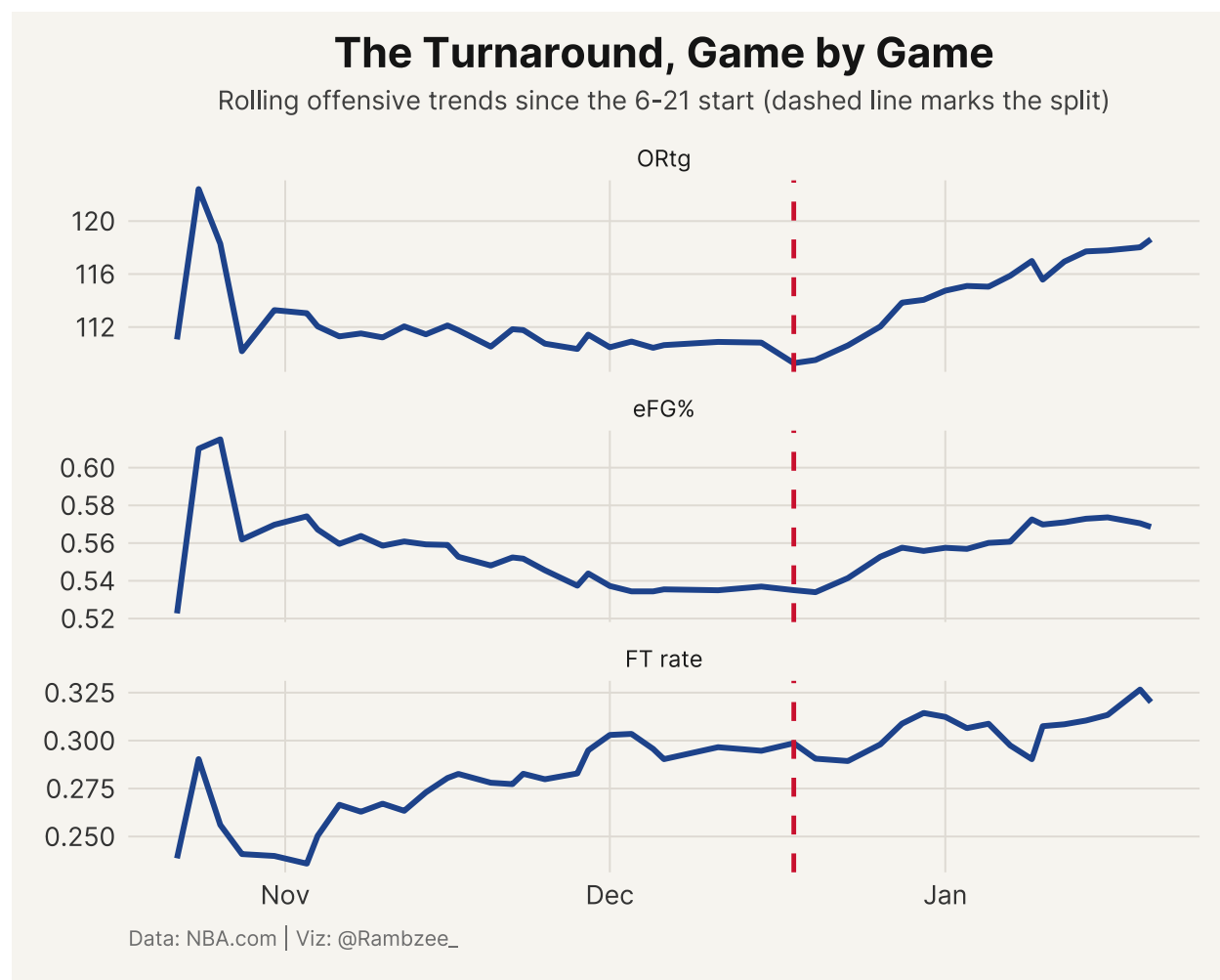


Figure 1: Rolling offensive indicators. Vertical line marks end of the start window.

The rolling trends point to a real shift. Offensive rating has steadily climbed after the early-season window and has held in the range of elite offenses. Free throws tell the story. The Clippers are executing possessions more cleanly and with more force, putting defenses in position to foul night after night.

3) League context (last 16 rank)

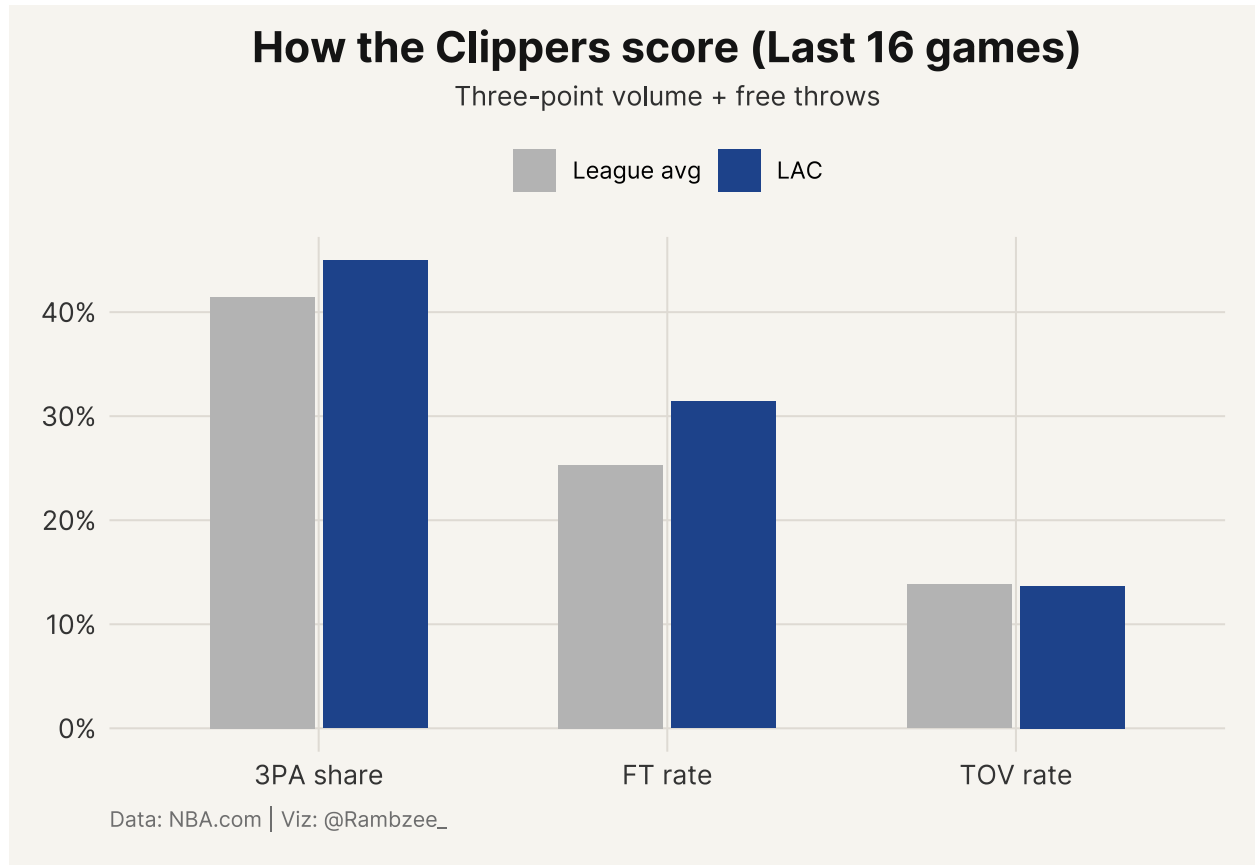
Table 2: League context: last 16 games.

Team	GP (W-L)	ORTg	ORTg rk	eFG	eFG rk	TOV%	TOV rk	FT rate	FT rk	3PA share	3PA rk
LAC	16 (13-3)	118.3	3	56.7%	4	13.7%	12	31.4%	1	45.0%	9

Table 3: Top 10 offenses in the last 16 games.

Rk	Team	W-L	ORTg	eFG	TOV%	FT rate
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1	GSW	11-5	118.9	58.2%	13.7%	23.4%
2	BOS	11-5	118.6	55.5%	12.5%	21.2%
3	LAC	13-3	118.3	56.7%	13.7%	31.4%
4	CHA	7-9	118.1	56.0%	14.3%	24.0%
5	MIN	9-7	117.6	57.1%	12.3%	26.4%
6	OKC	11-5	116.5	56.5%	11.2%	26.1%
7	CHI	9-7	115.6	56.5%	12.3%	21.0%
8	CLE	10-6	115.2	57.1%	15.0%	22.4%
9	DEN	8-8	114.8	55.8%	11.6%	28.2%
10	PHX	12-4	114.8	54.4%	14.4%	22.9%



Over the last 15 games, the Clippers rank third in offensive rating league-wide, trailing only Boston & Golden State in that span. In a league where offense is abundant, the separation comes from how they score, not how fast they're scoring. They play a slower, more deliberate style, pairing heavy three-point volume (~45% of their shots) with an elite free-throw rate. That combination lets them control possessions and squeeze efficiency out of the half court, resulting in a 118.3 offensive rating built on cerebral play.

The Stars

Table 4: Harden/Leonard - season counting stats

Player	G	MPG	PTS	AST	TRB	FG_pct	3P_pct	2P_pct	eFG	FT_pct	TOV
James Harden	40	35.7	26.0	8.0	4.8	42.3%	34.2%	50.7%	51.0%	89.7%	3.6

Kawhi Leonard	30	33.8	28.2	3.5	6.3	49.7%	39.9%	55.6%	57.2%	94.1%	2.1
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Table 5: Harden/Leonard WOWY - On/Off lineup splits

Lineup	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET_fmt
Harden ON, Leonard OFF	761	116.5	121.0	-4.5
Harden ON, Leonard ON	665	124.9	119.1	+5.8
Leonard ON, Harden OFF	348	112.2	110.5	+1.8
Harden OFF, Leonard OFF	305	103.2	112.0	-8.8

While the Clippers’ turnaround has been driven by better team execution, it has been anchored by their two stars. James Harden and Kawhi Leonard still run the offense, supplying control, shot creation, and dependable scoring that let the Clippers play at a slower pace without bogging down. Their production and impact on the floor help explain why the offense found its footing so quickly once the details started to clean up.

What Does This All Mean?

The Clippers are still a flawed team, with real questions around age, health, and athleticism. Even so, they are far more competent than their 6–21 start suggested.

Kawhi Leonard has played at a borderline MVP level during this stretch, while James Harden continues to function as one of the game’s best floor-raisers. Combined with a team playing with renewed effort and clarity, it’s easy to see why the results have flipped so sharply.

This team may not be a true title contender, but that isn’t the point. For an aging roster without its own first-round pick, stabilizing into a strong, competitive playoff team matters. Whether or not they push past that ceiling, the Clippers have already pulled off one of the more impressive midseason turnarounds in recent memory.